

Dimensions of subjective well-being:

Happiness, Life satisfaction

Definitions:

Subjective well-being (SWB) is defined as "people's cognitive and affective evaluations of their lives" (Diener, Lucas, & Oishi, 2002, p. 63).

Veenhoven (1997, p. 34) describes it similarly: "how good [life] feels, how well it meets expectations, how desirable it is deemed to be, etc."

In general, the concept involves two broad elements (Kashdan, 2004):

The **cognitive element** refers to what one thinks about his or her life satisfaction in global terms (life as a whole) and in specific domain terms (in specific areas of life such as work, relationships, family life, career, and so forth).

The **affective element** refers to emotions, moods and feelings. High SWB means when Affect is considered positive when the emotions, moods and feelings experienced are frequent and pleasant (e.g. joy, elation, pride, hope, affection etc.) Affect is deemed negative, though, when the emotions, moods and feelings experienced are unpleasant (e.g. guilt, anger, shame, jealousy, and disappointment etc.)

When we think about and appraise our lives, we compare our perceived status against our own standards of desirability. This is the subjective element of **cognitive appraisal**.

Likewise, different things are associated with positive affect for different people. This is the subjective aspect of **affective appraisal**.

Do you believe wellbeing means the same thing to everyone? If we all enjoy and value different things, how is it possible to understand happiness? Doesn't that make measuring happiness extremely difficult?

Positive psychology is concerned with how people can do well, be well, feel well, and flourish over the long term. And subjective wellbeing (SWB) is one way to understand what this means to different people.

The Concept of Subjective Well-Being

A person who has a high level of satisfaction with their life, and who experiences a greater positive affect and little or less negative affect, would be deemed to have a high level of SWB [or in simpler terms, be very happy].

The concept of SWB falls within the 'hedonic' perspective that defines well-being or happiness as being fundamentally about maximising pleasure and avoiding or minimizing pain.

This differs from the 'eudaimonic' (eudaimonic) perspective which, as Waterman (1993) stated, is where one lives in accordance with one's daimon, or 'true self'. This perspective places focus on meaning in life and self-realization, and the extent to which a person fully integrates this into his or her life.

Eudaimonic well-being refers to the subjective experiences associated with eudaimonia or living a life of virtue in pursuit of human excellence. The phenomenological experiences derived from such living include self-actualization, personal expressiveness, and vitality.

Measuring Subjective Well-Being

Subjective well-being (SWB) is a self-reported measure of well-being, typically obtained by questionnaire.

When psychologists measure SWB, they are measuring how people think and feel about their lives.

So if we wanted to measure our SWB, what precisely would we evaluate? (below 3 factors)

SWB is most often thought of as having three components (Diener, 1984; Busseri & Sadava, 2011; Tov & Diener, 2013):

The three components of SWB are:

positive affect

negative affect

life satisfaction

These are independent factors that should be measured and studied separately (Andrews & Withey, 1976, Lucas et al., 1996). Thus, the presence of positive affect does not mean the absence of negative affect and vice versa.

SWB is defined as: satisfaction with life; high positive affect low negative affect. Life satisfaction encompasses the cognitive component of happiness when individuals rate the way their life has become to be. Diener argues that it refers to discrepancy between the present situation and what is thought to be the ideal or deserved standard (Veenhoven, 1991).

There needs to be a balance between the experiencing of positive and negative affect as well as an acknowledgement of the difference in frequency versus intensity of positive affect (Diener et al., 1991).

Ultimately, people who report higher levels of SWB tend to demonstrate higher levels of creativity, increased task persistence, multitasking, being systematic, optimism, attending to relevant negative information; longevity, less vulnerability to illness, sociability, trust, helpfulness, and less hostility and less self-centredness (Diener, 2000).

Why Is SWB Important?

There are many reasons why subjective wellbeing matters to individuals and society as a whole.

Quality of life

Our affective experiences and overall emotional wellbeing are central to our quality of life as individuals (Skevington & Böhnke, 2018).

People who feel satisfied with their lives and frequently experience good feelings such as joy, contentment, and hope are more inclined to be seen as enjoying a high quality of life.

Measures of SWB can be used to inform policy decisions, academic curricula, and social initiatives that contribute to a better quality of life for citizens and communities across the world (OECD Better Life, 2013).

Happiness:

Are happiness and subjective wellbeing the same?

Happiness is often equated(similar) with SWB in the literature, media, and more. In recent times, however, the latter is more widely thought of as the main affective component of the former (Machado, de Oliveira, Peregrino, & Cantilino, 2019). This means that SWB encompasses more than just happiness. By incorporating life satisfaction into SWB measures, we include consideration of past experiences and future expectations.

Commonsense Definitions of Happiness:

Have you ever asked someone about his or her views on happiness? I encourage you to ask friends and associates of various ages and backgrounds, "How do you define happiness in your life? What are some benchmarks or signs of your

happiness?" You will be surprised by the diversity of answers and refreshed and entertained by the many stories accompanying people's responses.

Since the dawn of ancient civilization, humans have struggled with pinning down a clear and all-encompassing definition of happiness (see, for example, Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*). Although there is no consensus on the definition of 'wellbeing' (Snyder and Lopez, 2007), there are several synonyms used throughout the literature to describe it, such as happiness, self-actualization, contentment, adjustment, economic prosperity, quality of life and wellbeing. But what exactly is happiness and is it really the pursuit of positive psychology?

Definition by Ed Diener (2000)

Diener described subjective well-being as an increase in happiness is the closest thing psychology has to a "general tonic" for "greater well-being".

The concept of 'happiness'

Happiness and Subjective Well-Being: Living a Pleasurable Life

Age-old Definitions of Happiness /Pursuit of Happiness

The Western societies believe that pursuit of happiness is just as important as our rights of life and liberty. Buddha left home in search of a more meaningful existence and ultimately found enlightenment, a sense of peace, and happiness. Aristotle believed that eudaimonia (human flourishing associated with living a life of virtue), or happiness based on a lifelong pursuit of meaningful, developmental goals (i.e., "doing what is worth doing"), was the key to the good life (Waterman, 1993). America's founders reasoned that the pursuit of happiness was

just as important as our unchallengeable rights of life and liberty. These age-old definitions of happiness, along with many other conceptualizations of emotional well-being, have had clear influences on the views of twentieth-and twenty-first-century scholars, but more recent psychological theory and genetic research have helped us to clarify happiness and its correlates..

Theories of happiness have been divided into three types:

1. Need/Goal Satisfaction Theories
2. Process/Activity Theories
3. Genetic/Personality Predisposition

Need/ Goal Satisfaction Theory

In regard to need/goal satisfaction theories, the leaders of particular schools of psychotherapy offered these ideas about happiness. For example, psychoanalytic and humanistic theorists (Sigmund Freud and Abraham Maslow, respectively) suggested that the reduction of tension or the satisfaction of needs lead to happiness. "Happiness as satisfaction" makes happiness a target of our psychological pursuits.

Process/Activity Theories

In the process/activity camp, theorists posit that engaging in particular life activities generates happiness. For example, Mike Csikszentmihalyi, who was one of the first 20th Century theorists to examine process/activity conceptualizations of happiness, proposed that people who experience flow (engagement in interesting activities that match or challenge task-related skills) in daily life tend to be very happy. Indeed, Csikszentmihalyi's work suggests that engagement in activity produces happiness.

Other process/activity theorists (e.g., Emmons, 1986; Snyder, 1994) have emphasized how the process of pursuing goals

generates energy and happiness. This pursuit of happiness perspective mirrors the United States' founders' promise of "life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness." Activities such as the practice of gratitude and kindness may also provide boosts in well-being for some groups. Empirical evidence exists for the fact that regular engagement in these types of positive acts can help individuals to improve their happiness over time by prescriptive use of tasks such as the writing of gratitude letters and purposeful acts of kindness (Sin & Lyubomirsky, 2009), or strategic use of optimism (Lyubomirsky, Dickerhoof, Boehm, & Sheldon, 2011).

Genetic/Personality Predisposition

Those who emphasize the genetic and personality predisposition theories of happiness (Diener & Larsen, 1984; Watson, 2000) tend to see happiness as stable personality trait emerging from biological and genetic factors.

Which Theory has Greater Merit?

Costa and McCrae (1988) found that happiness changed little over a 6-year period, thereby giving weight to theories of personality-based or biologically determined happiness. Demonstrating this link between happiness and personality, Lucas and Fujita (2000) showed that extroversion and neuroticism, two of the big 5 factors of personality (openness, conscientiousness, extroversion, agreeableness, neuroticism), were closely related to the characteristics of happiness. Studies of the biological or genetic determinants of happiness have found that up to 40% of positive emotionality and 55% of negative emotionality are genetically based. Obviously, this leaves about 50% of the

variance in happiness that is not explained by biological components.

Overall, therefore, a thorough understanding of happiness necessitates an examination of genetic factors and the variables suggested by need/goal satisfaction and the activity/process theorists.

21st Century Definitions of Happiness

The scholars whose ideas about well-being are more consistent with Aristotle's views on eudaimonia believe that happiness and well-being are not synonymous. In this latter perspective, eudaimonia is comprised of happiness and meaning. Stated in a simple formula, **Well-being = Happiness + Meanings** In order to subscribe to this later view of well being, one must understand virtue and the social implications of daily behavior.

Modern Western psychology has focused primarily on a post materialistic view of happiness that emphasizes pleasure, satisfaction, and life meaning.

Describing a new model of happiness, Lyubomirsky, Sheldon, and Schkade (2005) propose that "a person's chronic happiness level is governed by three major factors:

1. A genetically determined set point for happiness
2. Happiness-relevant circumstantial factors
3. Happiness-relevant activities and practices

Seligman divides happiness into three types:

1. The Pleasant Life: Pleasure & Positive Emotion

Seligman describes the pleasant life as having as many pleasures as possible and learning the skills to amplify them.

2. **The Good Life:** Flow & Engagement

The second type of happiness by Seligman is The Good Life that includes pleasure vs flow, Identify Signature Strengths (www.authentichappiness.org) and Re-craft Work, Love, and Play.

3. **Meaningful Life:** Meaning & Purpose

The third type is Meaningful Life that focuses on the aims of life and Knowing your signature strengths and use in the service of something larger than you.

References Snyder, C.R., & Lopez, S.J. (2007). Positive Psychology. London: Sage Publications (pp. 132-144).

Life satisfaction

Life satisfaction (global judgments of one's life) and satisfaction with specific life domains (e.g. work satisfaction) are considered cognitive components of SWB./The term "happiness" is sometimes used in regards to SWB and has been defined variously as "satisfaction of desires and goals" (therefore related to life satisfaction), as a "majority of positive over negative affect" (therefore related to emotional components of SWB), as "contentment", and as a "consistent, optimistic mood state" and may imply an affective evaluation of one's life as a whole./

Life satisfaction can also be known as the "stable" component in one's life. Affective concepts of SWB can be considered in terms of momentary emotional states as well as in terms of longer-term moods and tendencies (i.e. how much positive and/or negative affect a person generally experiences over any given period of time).

Life satisfaction and in some research happiness are typically considered over long durations, up to one's lifetime. "Quality of life" has also been studied as a conceptualization of SWB. Although its exact definition varies, it is usually measured as an

aggregation of well-being across several life domains and may include both subjective and objective components.

Who is happy?

Now that we are clear about how we are defining happiness within this chapter, we will move onto the data that we currently have on who is happy in the world. In reality, and from hundreds of thousands of data sets, it appears that most people are indeed happy (Myers, 2000). Although it is rare to be at the high end, the majority of people on Earth score in the 'somewhat satisfied set-point' (Diener and Diener, 1995: 653). This means that at any given time point, the majority of people view stimuli and circumstances as positive. Thus, a common assumption that most people view themselves as unhappy appears to be false (Myers, 2000). For example, most people (more than two-thirds) in most samples (across age, race, sex, measures) view themselves as 'above average' in happiness. The exceptions to this appear to be those that are 'hospitalized, alcoholics, newly imprisoned inmates, new therapy clients and students living under political suppression' (Myers, 2000).

Furthermore, the good news is that, as individuals, we have a lot of influence in whether or not we become happy. Researchers postulate that after genetics (50 per cent) (Tellegen et al., 1988) and life circumstances (10 per cent) we have control over approximately 40 per cent

of our happiness levels (also called the '40 per cent solution') (Sheldon and Lyubomirsky, 2004, 2006, 2007, 2009; Lyubomirsky, 2006, 2008).

Happiest places on Earth

So which are the current happiest countries? Denmark, for example, has consistently scored within the highest ranking countries in happiness levels across the globe (8.0).

Rank	Country
1	Costa Rica
2	Denmark
3	Iceland
4	Switzerland
5	Finland
6	Mexico
7	Norway
8	Canada
9	Panama
10	Sweden

TABLE 3.1 Happiest places on Earth (World Database of Happiness, 2010)

Unhappiest countries on earth (1995-2007)

Rank	Country
1	Zimbabwe
2	Armenia
3	Moldova
4	Belarus
5	Ukraine
6	Albania
7	Iraq
8	Bulgaria
9	Georgia
10	Russia

TABLE 3.2 Unhappiest places on earth (World Values Survey for 1995–2007)

/SWB and mental health

Mental health is critical to SWB and vice versa. Very crudely, mental health can be considered the absence of negative psychological symptoms and the presence of positive ones (Abdel-Khalek & Lester, 2013).

What's important to note here is that the absence of illness and disease is not considered enough for people to have good mental health, and it's where SWB comes into the definition.

By recognizing the role of feelings such as joy, life satisfaction, fulfillment, purpose, and contentment in life, we have a more holistic mental health concept. In turn, we can better understand how to facilitate its development in individuals and populations (Keyes, 2006).